

Vodafone Deploys Open Source to Reduce Vendor Lock-in

Vodafone India is the second largest player in the Indian telecom sector after Bharti Airtel, with a base of over 200 million subscribers. The telco giant uses digital GSM technologies on 900MHz and 1800MHz frequencies to offer traditional 2G and 3G services alongside an advanced 4G LTE network.



Apart from offering mobile device users in the country with seamless connectivity, Vodafone India is a large consumer of open source software. The subsidiary of the UK-based Vodafone Group Plc has a talent pool of over 100 people involved in major open source developments. Moreover, it considers open source as the key factor when it comes to deciding the architecture for all its partners.

“Vodafone India ensures that all partner contracts have open source as the key architecture deciding point,” says Vikas Grover, former chief information officer, Vodafone India.

Vodafone's developer team uses traditional open source solutions such as Java, Drools, Eclipse Mars and Apache Hadoop as well as the new versions of R, Python, Cassandra and Struts, among various others.

To enhance existing offerings and to discover new developments, the team accesses well-known repositories. “We sometimes take help from the contributors available on GitHub and Stack Overflow,” says Rahul Gupta, VP for solution and planning of IT, Vodafone India.

Developers at Vodafone India also take support from product sites. Additionally, the telco has some partner-managed solutions that are taken care of by third parties.

Moving away from proprietary technologies

Vodafone India had initially relied on proprietary technologies. But with the massive advances in the open source world, the operator has decided to make the shift to community solutions.

“Growth, cost reduction and architecture improvement initiatives compel us to keep transforming our IT state year-over-year. This allows us to review our technology stack, avoid vendor lock-in and analyse cost implications, resulting in wider implementation and induction of open source technologies,” Gupta told *Open Source For You*.

Customer Point of Sale (CPOS)

One of the technologies to have recently received open source treatment by Vodafone engineers is a customer onboarding